

Research Paper 1: The Hebrew Word Elohim (אֱלֹהִים) and Genesis 1:1

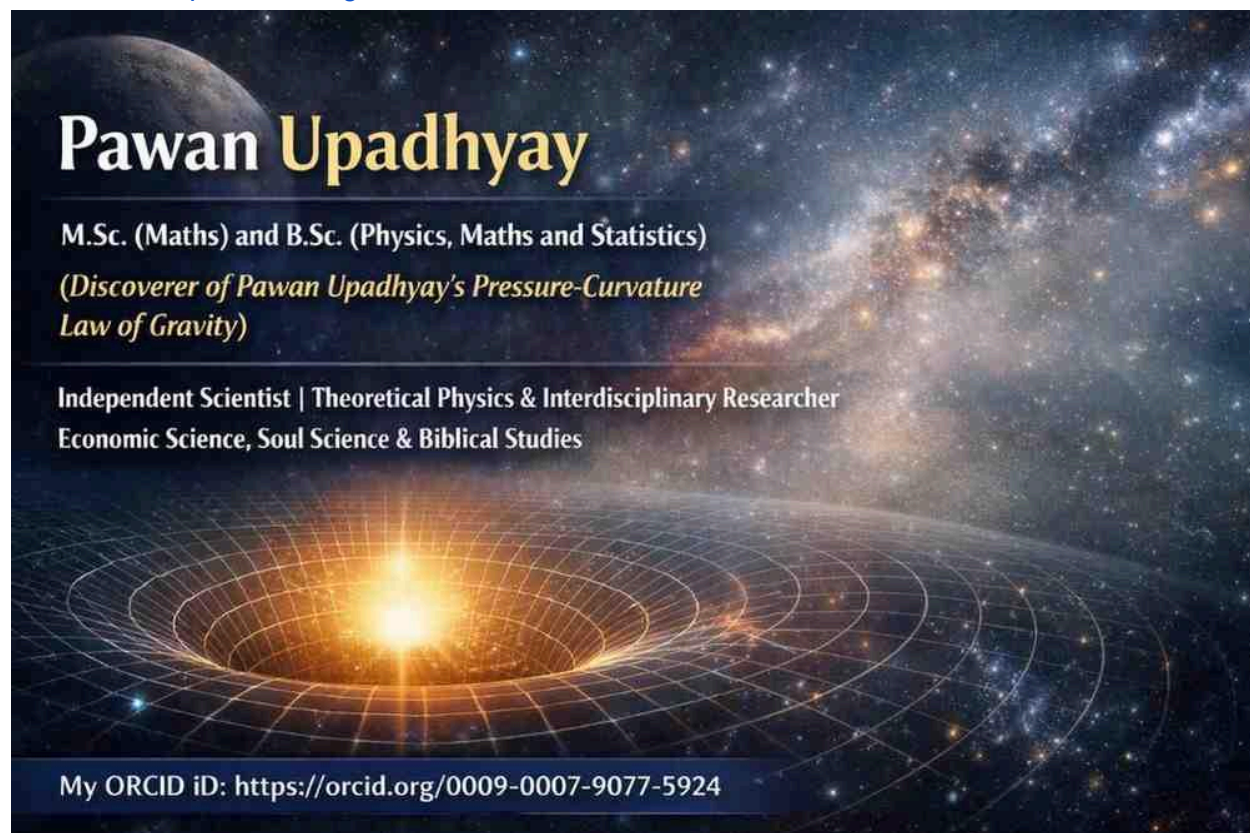
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Abstract

The Hebrew word אֱלֹהִים (*’ēlōhîm*, commonly “Elohim”) is one of the most significant divine designations in the Hebrew Bible. Its form is grammatically plural, yet when it refers to the God of Israel it frequently governs singular verbs. This feature has generated extensive discussion concerning Hebrew grammar, ancient Israelite theology, and Christian interpretations of the Trinity.

Genesis 1:1 provides an especially important example:

בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים אֶת הַשָּׁמַיִם וְאֶת הָאָרֶץ

Bərē 'šīt bārā ' 'ēlōhîm 'ēt haššāmayim wə 'ēt hā 'āreṣ.

“In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.”

— Genesis 1:1

A careful study shows that *Elohim* cannot linguistically be translated as “Trinity.” Nevertheless, within Christian theology, Genesis 1:1 and the broader biblical revelation of God are understood within the doctrine of the Trinity: **one God in three Persons—Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.**

1. Introduction

The opening words of Genesis constitute one of the most foundational statements in biblical theology:

“In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.”

The Hebrew text identifies the Creator as אֱלֹהִים (*Elohim*).

The study of *Elohim* is particularly interesting because the noun has a **plural grammatical form**, while the verb associated with it in Genesis 1:1—בָּרָא (*bārā*’, “created”)—is **singular**.

This raises an important question:

Why does the Hebrew Bible use a plural-form noun for God while using singular grammar to describe His action?

The answer requires careful distinction between Hebrew grammar and later theological interpretation.

2. The Hebrew Word Elohim

Hebrew

אֱלֹהִים

Transliteration

'ēlōhîm / Elohim

Basic meaning

Depending upon context, *Elohim* can refer to:

- God
- the God of Israel
- gods/deities
- divine or supernatural beings in certain contexts

When used for the God of Israel, English Bibles normally translate it simply as:

God

3. The Form of the Word

Elohim ends with:

ים (-îm)

This is normally a **masculine plural ending** in Biblical Hebrew.

Compare:

- **מֶלֶךְ (*melekh*)** — king
- **מְלָכִים (*melākhîm*)** — kings

Thus, *Elohim* has the outward grammatical form of a plural noun.

However, grammatical number must be determined from the entire construction and context.

When *Elohim* refers to Israel's God, it frequently appears with **singular verbs and singular modifiers**.

Genesis 1:1 is a classic example.

4. Elohim and the Hebrew Root

The precise historical development of the various Hebrew forms is complex, but *Elohim* is traditionally associated with the Hebrew family of divine terms including:

אל — *El*

Meaning:

God, deity, mighty one

אלוה — *Eloah*

Meaning:

God, deity

אלהים — *Elohim*

Meaning:

God/gods, depending on context

The word therefore belongs to the central vocabulary through which the Hebrew Bible speaks about deity.

5. Genesis 1:1 — Full Hebrew Text

Hebrew

בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים אֶת הַשָּׁמַיִם וְאֶת הָאָרֶץ:

Transliteration

Bērē' šīt bārā' 'ēlōhīm 'ēt haššāmayim wə'ēt hā'āreṣ.

English

“In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.”

6. Genesis 1:1 — Word-by-Word Study

There are **seven major Hebrew elements** in the verse.

Hebrew	Transliteration	Meaning
בְּרֵאשִׁית	<i>bərē'šît</i>	in the beginning
בָּרָא	<i>bārā'</i>	created
אֱלֹהִים	<i>'ēlōhîm</i>	God
אֶת	<i>'ēt</i>	direct-object marker
הַשָּׁמַיִם	<i>haššāmayim</i>	the heavens
וְאֶת	<i>wə'ēt</i>	and + direct-object marker
הָאָרֶץ	<i>hā'āreṣ</i>	the earth

Now we can examine each one.

7. בְּרֵאשִׁית — *Bərē'šît*

Hebrew

בְּרֵאשִׁית

Meaning

“In the beginning”

The word is related to ראש (*rosh*), meaning:

head, beginning, first, chief

The prefix בְּ (*bə-*) generally means:

in, at, by, with

Thus:

בְּ + רֵאשִׁית

gives the sense:

“in the beginning.”

Genesis therefore begins by directing attention to the beginning of the created order.

8. בָּרָא — *Bārā'*

Hebrew

בָּרָא

Meaning

“created”

This is a verb from the root:

ברא — B-R-'

In Genesis 1, *bārā'* is particularly associated with God's creative activity.

Importantly, the verb is **singular**.

This becomes extremely significant when it is followed by:

אֱלֹהִים — *Elohim*

The construction is:

בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים
bārā' Elohim
“God created.”

The verb is singular even though *Elohim* has a plural form.

9. אֱלֹהִים — *Elohim*

Hebrew

אֱלֹהִים

Meaning in Genesis 1:1

“God”

This is the central word of our study.

Grammatically, *Elohim* has a plural form.

Yet Genesis 1:1 does **not** say:

“Elohim created” with a plural verb.

Instead:

בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים
bārā' 'ēlōhîm

The verb בָּרָא is singular.

Therefore, the Hebrew construction presents **Elohim as a singular acting subject** in this context.

10. Does the Plural Elohim Prove the Trinity?

This requires careful scholarship.

It would be incorrect to say:

“Elohim means three persons.”

The Hebrew word itself does **not** contain the meaning “Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.”

Nor does the **-im** ending mean “three.”

However, Christians have historically noticed that:

1. *Elohim* has a plural form.
2. The God of Israel is nevertheless presented as one.
3. *Elohim* frequently takes singular grammar when referring to Israel's God.
4. Other biblical passages reveal distinctions involving Father, Son, and Spirit.

Consequently, Christians may regard the linguistic form of *Elohim* as **compatible with Trinitarian theology**, but the doctrine of the Trinity comes from the **whole biblical witness**, not from the morphology of one word.

11. אֶת — *’Et*

The next word is:

אֶת

This word is extremely important grammatically.

It normally functions as the **definite direct-object marker** in Biblical Hebrew.

It does not have a simple English equivalent.

In Genesis 1:1:

בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים אֶת...

literally indicates:

“God created [the definite object]...”

Therefore, *’et* tells the reader that what follows is the direct object of the verb.

12. הַשָּׁמַיִם — *Haššāmayim*

Hebrew

הַשָּׁמַיִם

Meaning

“the heavens”

The prefix:

הַ (*ha-*)

means:

“the”

The noun:

שָׁמַיִם (*šāmayim*)

is conventionally translated:

heavens / heaven

The form itself has a plural appearance.

Thus:

הַ שָׁמַיִם

means:

“the heavens.”

13. וְ — *Wə'ēt*

This consists of two elements:

וְ (*wə-*) = and

אֶת (*'ēt*) = direct-object marker

Therefore:

וְ אֶת = “and [the direct object marker]”

It introduces the second object of God's creative action.

14. הָאָרֶץ — *Hā'āreṣ*

Hebrew

הָאָרֶץ

Meaning

“the earth”

The prefix:

הַ (hā-)

means:

the

The noun:

אָרֶץ (’eres)

can mean:

land, earth, territory

In Genesis 1:1 the natural translation is:

“the earth.”

15. Grammatical Structure of Genesis 1:1

The sentence can be represented as:

בְּרֵאשִׁית

In the beginning

↓

בָּרָא

created

↓

אֱלֹהִים

God

↓

אֶת הַשָּׁמַיִם

the heavens

↓

וְאֶת הָאָרֶץ
and the earth

The fundamental structure is:

Time + Verb + Subject + Object 1 + Object 2

“In the beginning + created + God + the heavens + and the earth.”

16. Theological Meaning of Genesis 1:1

Genesis 1:1 establishes several foundational theological propositions.

1. God existed before creation

The verse does not introduce God as something that was created.

Instead, God is presented as the Creator.

2. Creation has a beginning

The biblical narrative begins with:

“In the beginning...”

Creation therefore has an origin.

3. God is the Creator

The subject is:

אֱלֹהִים — Elohim

And the verb is:

בָּרָא — created

4. The heavens and earth belong to the created order

The expression:

“the heavens and the earth”

functions as a comprehensive expression for the created universe.

Thus Genesis begins with a fundamental distinction:

Creator → creation

God is the Creator; everything else belongs to creation.

17. Elohim and the Christian Doctrine of the Trinity

Christian theology later articulates God as:

One God in three Persons: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

The doctrine does **not** mean:

three gods

Instead:

One divine Being → three distinct Persons

This distinction is essential.

The Christian understanding can therefore be expressed:

Elohim — one God

Father — God

Son — God

Holy Spirit — God

Yet:

Father ≠ Son ≠ Holy Spirit

while:

Father, Son, and Holy Spirit ≠ three gods

This is the theological doctrine of the **Trinity**.

18. Genesis 1:26 and the “Us” Question

Genesis 1:26 says:

“Let us make man in our image...”

The Hebrew expression contains plural language:

נַעֲשֶׂה — *na‘āseh*
“Let us make”

and:

בְּצַלְמֵנוּ — *bəṣalmēnū*
“in our image”

Christians have sometimes connected this with the Trinity.

However, from a historical-linguistic perspective, there are several scholarly explanations for the plural language, including interpretations involving a divine council or a majestic/deliberative form.

Therefore, **Genesis 1:26 by itself should not be treated as an unambiguous statement of the Trinity.**

Christian theology sees it within the larger biblical revelation.

19. Elohim Does Not Mean “Three Gods”

This point is particularly important.

The statement:

Elohim = three Gods

is incorrect.

Likewise:

Elohim = Trinity

is not a lexical translation.

A more academically precise statement is:

Elohim is a Hebrew divine designation whose plural form is used frequently with singular grammar when referring to the God of Israel. Christian theology understands this one God as the triune God revealed as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

That preserves both the Hebrew grammar and Christian theology.

20. A Christian Theological Reading of Genesis 1:1

From a Christian perspective, Genesis 1:1 can be read together with the New Testament.

Genesis begins:

“In the beginning God created...”

John 1:1–3 begins with:

“In the beginning...”

and identifies the **Word** as being with God and participating in creation.

John 1:3 teaches that all things came into being through the Word.

Christian theology therefore connects:

Genesis 1 — God creates

with

John 1 — the Word participates in creation

and later passages concerning the **Holy Spirit**.

This provides a much stronger theological foundation for Trinitarian interpretation than simply arguing from the plural ending of *Elohim*.

21. Conclusion

The Hebrew word אֱלֹהִים (*Elohim*) is a profound and important term in biblical Hebrew.

Its grammatical form is plural, but when it refers to the God of Israel it commonly takes **singular grammatical agreement**. Genesis 1:1 provides a particularly clear example:

בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים

Bərē' šīt bārā' 'ēlōhîm

“In the beginning God created...”

The **singular verb** בָּרָא (*bārā'*) is significant because it presents *Elohim* as a singular acting subject in this sentence.

From a linguistic perspective, however, *Elohim* does not mean “Trinity.” The plural morphology cannot by itself establish the Christian doctrine of the Trinity.

From a Christian theological perspective, however, the one **Elohim** is understood as the one God who is eternally **Father, Son, and Holy Spirit**. The doctrine of the Trinity therefore rests upon the broader biblical testimony rather than upon the word *Elohim* alone.

Central conclusion

Elohim is not the Hebrew word for “Trinity.” It is a Hebrew designation for God (and, in other contexts, gods/divine beings). In Genesis 1:1, Elohim is the singular Creator. Christian theology identifies this one God as the Triune God—Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Key Hebrew text

בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים אֶת הַשָּׁמַיִם וְאֶת הָאָרֶץ:

Bərē' šīt bārā' 'ēlōhîm 'ēt haššāmayim wə'ēt hā'āreṣ.

“In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.”

Note: Elohim and the Three Persons of God

Elohim (אֱלֹהִים) is the Hebrew word commonly translated as “**God**” in the Old Testament. The word has a plural grammatical form, yet when it refers to the God of Israel, it commonly takes **singular grammatical agreement**.

From a **Christian theological perspective**, *Elohim* can be used to express the truth that there is **one God who exists eternally in three distinct Persons**:

1. **God the Father**
2. **God the Son**
3. **God the Holy Spirit**

Therefore:

Elohim = One God, three Persons.

This does **not** mean three gods. The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are distinct Persons, but they share the **one divine nature**.

Genesis 1:1 says:

בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים

Bərē'šît bārā' 'ĕlōhîm

“In the beginning God created...”

The plural-form noun **Elohim** is accompanied by the singular verb **bārā'** (“created”). For Christian theology, this provides an interesting linguistic feature that can be considered alongside the wider biblical revelation of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Important qualification: *Elohim* does not literally translate as **“Trinity.”** The Trinity is a **Christian theological doctrine** derived from the broader biblical testimony. Thus, the best formulation is:

“Elohim is the one God, whom Christian faith understands as eternally existing in three Persons: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.”

Note: Elohim, YHWH, and Adonai — Hebrew Word Study

Exodus 3:15 — Full Verse

Hebrew

וַיֹּאמֶר עוֹד אֱלֹהִים אֶל־מֹשֶׁה כֹּה־תֹאמַר אֶל־בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵי אֲבֹתֵיכֶם אֱלֹהֵי אַבְרָהָם אֱלֹהֵי יִצְחָק וְאֱלֹהֵי יַעֲקֹב שְׁלַחְנִי אֵלֵיכֶם זֶה־שְּׁמִי לְעֹלָם וְזֶה זִכְרִי לְדֹר דֹּר:

Transliteration

Vayomer 'od Elohim el-Moshe, koh tomar el-benei Yisrael: YHWH Elohei avoteikhem, Elohei Avraham, Elohei Yitzchak, ve-Elohei Ya'akov, shelachani aleikhem; zeh-shemi le'olam, vezeh zichri ledor dor.

English

“God also said to Moses, ‘Thus you shall say to the children of Israel: “The LORD, the God of your fathers—the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob—has sent me to you.” This is My name forever, and this is My memorial-name to all generations.”

— Exodus 3:15

1. Elohim — אֱלֹהִים

Elohim is a Hebrew designation for **God**.

- Hebrew: אֱלֹהִים
- Transliteration: 'Ēlōhîm
- Meaning: **God / deity**
- Grammatical form: plural-form noun

When *Elohim* refers to the God of Israel, it commonly takes **singular grammatical agreement**.

For example, Genesis 1:1 says:

בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים

Bərē šît bārā' 'ēlōhîm

“In the beginning God created...”

Here בָּרָא (*bārā'*), “created,” is singular.

Thus, *Elohim* in this context refers to **one God**, not three gods.

2. YHWH — יהוה

The Hebrew name:

יהוה

is known as the **Tetragrammaton**, meaning “four letters.”

The four letters are:

יהוה

Transliterated:

YHWH

The pronunciation **Yahweh** is commonly used by modern scholars.

Many English Bibles translate YHWH as:

LORD

In Exodus 3:15, God specifically identifies **YHWH** as His name:

זֶה־שְׁמִי לְעֹלָם

Zeh-shemi le'olam

“This is My name forever.”

Therefore, YHWH is not simply another word meaning “god.” It functions as the **distinctive divine name** of Israel's God.

3. Adonai — אֲדֹנָי

Adonai means:

“My Lord” / “Lord”

Hebrew:

אֲדֹנָי

Transliteration:

'Adōnāy

It is related to:

אֲדֹן (*'ādōn*)

meaning:

lord, master, ruler

Adonai therefore emphasizes God's **lordship, authority, and sovereignty**.

4. Why Adonai Is Connected with YHWH

Jewish reading tradition traditionally avoids pronouncing the divine name **YHWH** aloud.

When the Hebrew text contains יהוה, the reader commonly says:

Adonai — “Lord.”

This practice is reflected in many English Bibles, where **YHWH** is represented by **LORD** in capital letters.

Therefore:

יהוה → **YHWH** → **LORD**

while:

אֲדֹנָי → **Adonai** → **Lord**

The distinction is particularly important when studying the Hebrew text.

5. Exodus 3:15 — The Three Important Words

Exodus 3:15 contains both **Elohim** and **YHWH**:

יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵי אֲבֹתֵינוּ

YHWH Elohei avoteikhem

Meaning:

“The LORD, the God of your fathers...”

Notice the relationship:

YHWH → the divine name

Elohei → “God of”

Avoteikhem → “your fathers”

Then the verse identifies:

the God of Abraham

the God of Isaac

the God of Jacob

This connects God's divine name with His covenant relationship with the patriarchs.

6. The Meaning of “This Is My Name Forever”

The most significant statement in Exodus 3:15 is:

זֶה־שְׁמִי לְעֹלָם

Zeh-shemi le 'olam

“This is My name forever.”

God tells Moses that **YHWH** is His name.

The verse therefore provides an important distinction:

Elohim identifies God as God.

YHWH identifies God's revealed covenant name.

Adonai identifies Him as Lord/Master.

7. Relationship to the Christian Doctrine of the Trinity

Christian theology teaches:

One God in three Persons: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Therefore, Christians can understand **Elohim, YHWH, and Adonai** as referring to the one true God when these terms are used of Israel's God.

However, we should distinguish **Hebrew meaning** from **Christian theological interpretation**.

Linguistically:

Elohim ≠ “Trinity”

YHWH ≠ “Trinity”

Adonai ≠ “Trinity”

Theologically:

The one God designated by these terms is understood by Christianity as:

Father + Son + Holy Spirit = One God

not:

Father + Son + Holy Spirit = three gods

8. Summary

Hebrew	Transliteration	Basic meaning	Main emphasis
אֱלֹהִים	<i>Elohim</i>	God	Deity / Creator
יְהוָה	<i>YHWH / Yahweh</i>	Divine name	God's revealed covenant name
אֲדֹנָי	<i>Adonai</i>	My Lord / Lord	Lordship and authority

Key theological statement

Elohim is the God who creates. YHWH is the revealed name of the covenant God. Adonai expresses His lordship and sovereignty. Christian faith understands this one God as eternally existing in three Persons: the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit.

Thus, Elohim, YHWH, and Adonai should not be treated as three different gods or as three different Hebrew words for the Trinity. They are distinct Hebrew designations and names associated with the one God of Israel, whose triune nature is understood through the broader Christian biblical revelation.

Research Paper 2: Elohim — The One God and the Holy Trinity

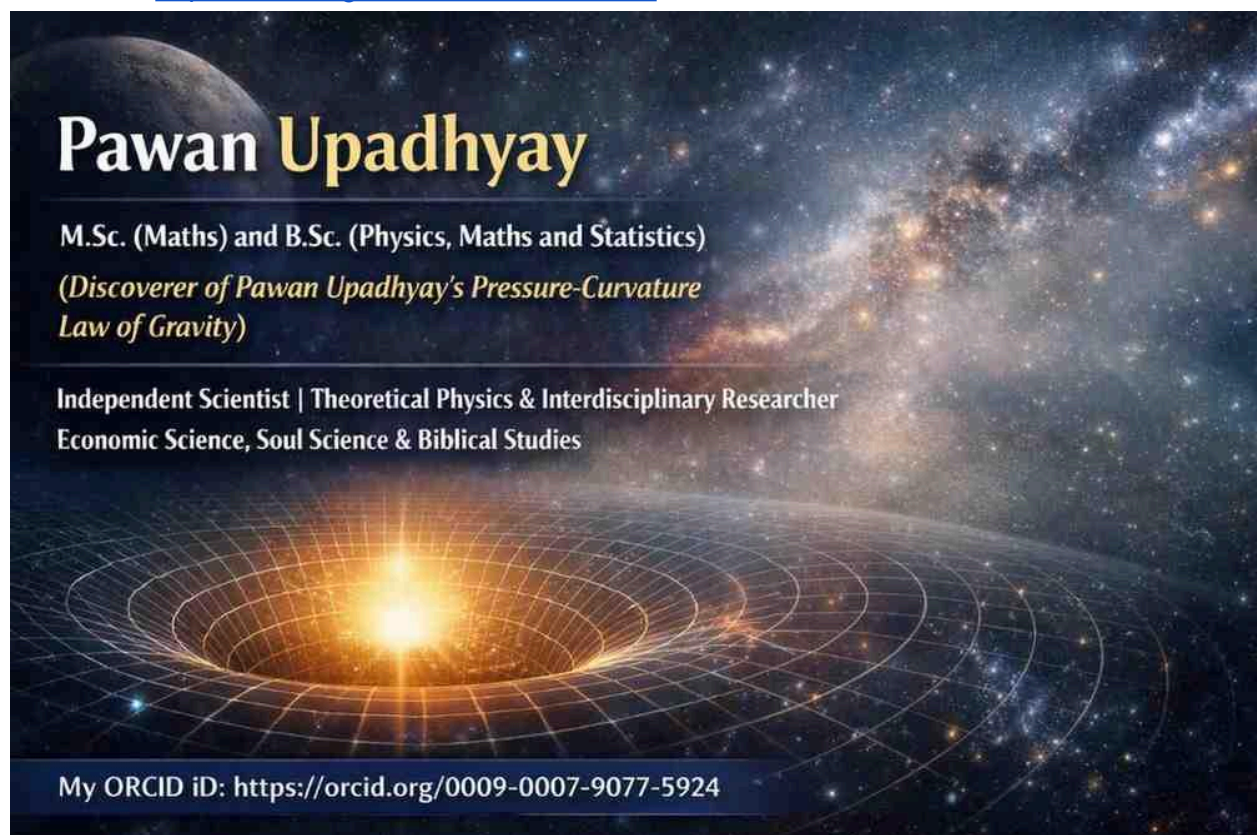
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Abstract

The Hebrew word **Elohim** (אֱלֹהִים) is one of the principal designations for God in the Hebrew Bible. Its grammatical form is plural, while its use for the God of Israel frequently occurs with singular grammatical agreement. This distinctive feature has attracted considerable attention in biblical Hebrew studies and Christian theology.

This paper examines the meaning and grammatical form of *Elohim*, particularly in **Genesis 1:1**, and considers its relationship to the Christian doctrine of the Trinity. The central theological proposition of this study is that **the Trinity is one God, not three Gods**. Christian theology understands the one divine Being as eternally existing in three distinct Persons: **the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit**.

It is important, however, to distinguish Hebrew linguistics from Christian theology. *Elohim* does not lexically mean “Trinity,” and its plural form alone does not prove the doctrine of the Trinity. Rather, Christians understand the *Elohim* of Scripture as the one true God and interpret the fuller biblical revelation as revealing this one God as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

1. Introduction

The Bible begins with a profound declaration:

“In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.”
— Genesis 1:1

The Hebrew word translated “**God**” is:

אֱלֹהִים — Elohim

The word is particularly interesting because **Elohim has a plural grammatical form**, yet Genesis 1:1 uses a **singular verb** with it.

The Hebrew text reads:

בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים

Bərē`šît bārā` `ēlōhîm

“In the beginning God created...”

This provides an important starting point for understanding *Elohim*.

The purpose of this paper is to examine:

1. The Hebrew meaning of *Elohim*.

2. Its grammatical form.
 3. Its use in Genesis 1:1.
 4. The relationship between its plural form and singular grammatical agreement.
 5. The distinction between *Elohim*, YHWH, and Adonai.
 6. The relationship between *Elohim* and Christian Trinitarian theology.
 7. Why the Trinity means **one God, not three Gods**.
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2. The Hebrew Word Elohim

Hebrew

אֱלֹהִים

Transliteration

ʾĒlōhîm

Common translation

God

Elohim belongs to the Hebrew vocabulary associated with deity and is related to Hebrew forms such as:

אֵל — El

and

אֱלֹהִי — Eloah

Depending on context, *Elohim* and related forms can refer to God, gods, or divine beings.

However, when *Elohim* refers specifically to the **God of Israel**, it frequently appears with singular grammatical agreement.

3. The Plural Form of Elohim

The ending:

ים (-îm)

is ordinarily a masculine plural ending in Hebrew.

Consequently:

Elohim is plural in grammatical form.

But grammatical form and theological number are not necessarily identical.

For the God of Israel, *Elohim* commonly behaves grammatically as a singular subject.

This is particularly clear in Genesis 1:1.

4. Genesis 1:1 — The Hebrew Text

Hebrew

בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים אֶת הַשָּׁמַיִם וְאֶת הָאָרֶץ:

Transliteration

Bērē' šît bārā' 'ēlōhîm 'ēt haššāmayim wə'ēt hā'āreṣ.

Translation

“In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.”

The central grammatical construction is:

בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים
bārā' Elohim

“God created.”

5. Word-by-Word Study of Genesis 1:1

5.1 בְּרֵאשִׁית — *Bērē' šît*

Meaning:

“In the beginning”

It introduces the beginning of the created order.

5.2 בָּרָא — *Bārā'*

Meaning:

“created”

This is a **singular verb**.

The verb is used with *Elohim* as its subject.

5.3 אֱלֹהִים — *Elohim*

Meaning:

“God”

The noun has a plural form, but in Genesis 1:1 it functions as the subject of the singular verb *bārā'*.

Thus:

Plural-form noun + singular verb

The verse presents **one acting Creator**.

5.4 אֶת — *'Et*

This is the Hebrew **definite direct-object marker**.

It indicates that the following noun is the direct object of the verb.

5.5 הַשָּׁמַיִם — *Haššāmayim*

Meaning:

“the heavens”

The prefix הַ (*ha-*) means “the.”

5.6 וְאֵת — *Wə'ēt*

This consists of:

וְ — *wə-* = and

plus:

אֵת — *'ēt* = direct-object marker

Thus:

“and [the direct object marker]...”

5.7 הָאָרֶץ — *Hā'āreṣ*

Meaning:

“the earth”

The noun *'ereṣ* can mean “earth,” “land,” or “territory,” depending on context.

In Genesis 1:1:

“the earth”

is the natural translation.

6. Elohim: Plural Form but One God

The central observation is:

Elohim has a plural form, but when referring to Israel's God it commonly takes singular grammatical agreement.

Genesis 1:1 demonstrates this:

בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים

Bārā' Elohim

“God created.”

The verb is singular.

Therefore, the verse does not present three separate creators.

It presents:

One Creator — Elohim.

This is an important distinction.

7. Does the Plural Form Mean Three?

No.

The plural ending **ים (-im)** does not mean:

“three.”

Therefore, it would be incorrect to argue:

“Elohim is plural, therefore it means three Gods.”

That conclusion does not follow from Hebrew grammar.

Likewise, *Elohim* does not literally translate as:

“Trinity.”

The word's lexical meaning must be distinguished from Christian theological interpretation.

8. Elohim and the One God

The Hebrew Bible strongly emphasizes the **oneness of God**.

Deuteronomy 6:4 declares:

שְׁמַע יִשְׂרָאֵל יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ יְהוָה אֶחָד

“Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one.”

The biblical concept of God is therefore fundamentally monotheistic.

The Christian doctrine of the Trinity does not abandon this belief.

Instead, Christianity maintains:

There is one God.

The Trinity does not introduce two additional gods.

9. The Trinity: One God, Not Three Gods

The central Christian doctrine can be stated precisely:

There is one God in three distinct Persons: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

The three Persons are:

1. The Father

God the Father.

2. The Son

God the Son, Jesus Christ.

3. The Holy Spirit

God the Holy Spirit.

Yet Christianity does **not** teach:

Father + Son + Holy Spirit = three Gods.

It teaches:

One divine Being — three Persons.

10. Being and Person

One of the best ways to understand the doctrine is to distinguish between **what** and **who**.

What is God?

One divine Being / nature.

Who is God?

Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Therefore:

One “what” — God.

Three “whos” — Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

This is why the Trinity is properly described as:

One God, three Persons.

11. Elohim and the Holy Trinity

Within Christian theology, it is therefore appropriate to say:

“Elohim refers to the one God whom Christianity understands as the Holy Trinity.”

Or:

“The Elohim of Scripture is the one true God, revealed in Christian faith as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.”

This is a theological statement.

It should not be confused with saying:

“Elohim is the Hebrew dictionary word for Trinity.”

The latter would be linguistically inaccurate.

12. Genesis 1:26 and Plural Language

Genesis 1:26 contains another notable feature:

“Let us make mankind in our image, in our likeness.”

The Hebrew includes plural expressions such as:

נַעֲשֶׂה — *na‘āśeh*
“Let us make”

and:

בְּצַלְמֵנוּ — *bəṣalmēnū*
“in our image”

Christian interpreters have historically connected this passage with the Trinity.

However, it is not universally accepted by Hebrew scholars as a direct grammatical statement of the Trinity. Other interpretations exist.

Therefore, Genesis 1:26 should be treated as **a possible theological correspondence**, rather than a standalone grammatical proof of the Trinity.

13. Elohim and YHWH

Another important distinction is between **Elohim** and **YHWH**.

Elohim

אֱלֹהִים

Meaning:

God / deity

YHWH

יהוה

This is the four-letter divine name, commonly transliterated:

YHWH

and commonly represented in English Bibles as:

LORD

The two terms can appear together.

For example:

יהוה אֱלֹהִים

YHWH Elohim

“LORD God.”

Thus, *Elohim* and *YHWH* are not names of two different gods.

14. Elohim and Adonai

Another important Hebrew term is:

אֲדֹנָי — **Adonai**

Meaning:

“My Lord” / “Lord.”

It is related to:

אֲדֹן — **Adon**

meaning:

lord, master, ruler.

The three terms can therefore be summarized:

Hebrew	Transliteration	Basic function
אֱלֹהִים	Elohim	God / deity
יהוה	YHWH	Divine covenant name
אֲדֹנָי	Adonai	Lord / My Lord

They are distinct Hebrew terms, but they can all refer to the **one God of Israel**.

15. Elohim and Christian Revelation

Christian theology understands the Old Testament revelation of God in light of the New Testament.

The New Testament identifies:

- the **Father** as God,
- the **Son** as divine,
- the **Holy Spirit** as divine,

while maintaining the fundamental belief that there is **one God**.

John 1:1–3 is especially important because it connects the **Word** with God and with creation.

Thus, Christians understand the Creator revealed in Genesis in relation to the fuller revelation of God in Christ and the Holy Spirit.

16. Theological Formula

The relationship can be expressed simply:

ELOHIM

↓

ONE GOD

↓

Father — Son — Holy Spirit

↓

HOLY TRINITY

The formula does **not** mean that *Elohim* linguistically means “three Persons.”

It means:

The one God called Elohim is understood by Christian theology as the Triune God.

17. What the Trinity Is Not

The doctrine of the Trinity should not be confused with:

Tritheism

Three separate Gods.

This is not the Christian doctrine of the Trinity.

Modalism

One Person appearing in three different modes.

This is also not the classical Christian doctrine.

Partialism

Father, Son, and Spirit are each one-third of God.

This is not the Christian doctrine either.

Instead:

The Father is fully God.

The Son is fully God.

The Holy Spirit is fully God.
There is one God.

18. Central Research Finding

The Hebrew evidence allows us to make the following observations:

Linguistically

Elohim is a plural-form Hebrew noun.

Grammatically

When referring to Israel's God, it frequently takes **singular grammatical agreement**.

Biblically

The God of Israel is presented as **one God**.

Christian theologically

The one God is understood as:

Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Therefore:

The Trinity is one God, not three Gods.

19. Conclusion

The study of **Elohim** (אֱלֹהִים) provides an important window into biblical language and theology.

In Genesis 1:1, *Elohim* has a plural grammatical form, but it is associated with the singular verb בָּרָא (*bārā*), “created.” The sentence therefore presents **one God as the Creator**.

The plural form of *Elohim* should not be treated as a mathematical statement meaning “three.” Nor does *Elohim* itself lexically mean “Trinity.”

Nevertheless, within Christian theology, the **one Elohim** is understood as the **one Triune God** revealed through Scripture.

The Christian doctrine can therefore be summarized:

One God — three Persons

Father — Son — Holy Spirit

Not:

Three Gods

Therefore, the most precise theological conclusion is:

“Elohim refers to the one true God. In Christian faith, this one God is the Holy Trinity: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. The Trinity is one God, not three Gods.”

This preserves the distinction between **Hebrew linguistic analysis** and **Christian theological interpretation**, while allowing *Elohim* to be understood within the Christian confession of the **one Triune God**.